the Signals and Major J. R. Sehgal, the DQ of 65 Brigade, did try to rally the troops into a fighting force but without any real success. Towards the evening the two officers realized the futility of staying on in Dirang Dzong. Arming themselves with brand new 7.62 SLR (self-loading) rifles just received from NATO—part of the massive inflow of American equipment (Prime Minister Nehru had hastily abandoned his non-alignment stance)—they too followed in the wake of their senior commanders who had fled in the morning.

Another junior officer, Lieutenant Vinay Shankar, also remained steadfastly at his gun position with his men, awaiting orders that never came. Writes Brigadier Darshan Khullar: ‘There was a strange quietude in the atmosphere around him (Vinay Shankar). There was no immediate threat, only a few wary Chinese lurking in the distance, at most a nuisance value. At about 1630 hours, when the Indian defences had acquired a near deserted look, the battery personnel spiked their 25-pounder guns and left Dirang Dzong.’ The 4th Indian Division, the famous Red Eagles who had created an aura of invincibility around themselves in North Africa during World War II, and had been commanded by Generals Pran Thapar, Bogey Sen and Bijji Kaul, had ceased to exist within thirty-six hours of the Chinese launching their attack on Se-la.

With the commanding officer of 19 MLI choosing to extricate his battalion rather than fall back to defend Dirang Dzong, he was displaying a behaviour pattern that was alarmingly familiar. So long as the Chinese played the game in a conventional manner, the Indians were in their element, as had been demonstrated by 1 Sikh at Bum-la and 4 Garhwal at Nuranang. However, the moment the Chinese got behind Indian set piece formations, under the garb of a ‘withdrawal’, most units chose self-preservation over valour. Ironically, during these unrehearsed withdrawals, the mobile and flexible Chinese forces then invariably decimated them.

Initially 19 MLI went westwards towards the Bhutan border, then moved south from Labrang towards Phudung and Morshing, escaping into Bhairabkunda in India from there. In the confusion of the immediate aftermath of the ceasefire, the spotlight was on the higher levels of command; it is a great pity that most of these commanding officers were not tried for cowardice and desertion. Most of these were excellent units with tremendous records—9 Punjab, 4 Grenadiers and 19 MLI—who were let down by their own leadership. The men and junior leadership, bewildered